Chalk and the history of the earth

Chalk is a soft white limestone made of the shells of tiny sea creatures that settled on an ancient sea floor over millions of years.

When a piece of chalk is crushed and examined under a microscope it shows thousands of small shells, called coccoliths and foraminifera, which tell the story of that vanished ocean.

The white cliffs along the south coast of England are the exposed edge of that ancient sea bed, lifted above the waves long after the creatures lived.